SYSDESIGN REFERENCE

Load Balancing Tradeoff Matrix

A decision-oriented comparison of alternatives and failure modes.

Distribute requests across healthy capacity without making the balancer a fragile choke point.

VERSION 1.0 REVIEW

REVIEWED THROUGH 2026-07-18

STATUS HUMAN REVIEW REQUIRED

SYSDESIGN / LOAD-BALANCING

SYSDESIGN

Load Balancing Tradeoff Matrix

CORE IDEA

Distribute requests across healthy capacity without making the balancer a fragile choke point.

Reference architecture decision chain

01	02	03	04
Layer 4 Vs Layer 7	Health Checks	Algorithms	Stickiness

Decisions to defend

+ Layer 4 vs Layer 7
+ health checks
+ algorithms
+ stickiness
+ and multi-zone failover.

Failure modes to test

+ Uneven load
+ stale health
+ connection draining
+ and regional failure.

Interview flow

- [ ] Clarify users, critical paths, and non-goals
- [ ] Estimate only scale that changes a decision
- [ ] Define API, data model, and source of truth
- [ ] Draw synchronous and asynchronous paths
- [ ] Pressure-test timeout, retry, overload, and recovery
- [ ] Close with tradeoffs and one alternative

Deep-dive drill

Load Balancing Tradeoff Matrix

Probe	What a strong answer makes explicit
How does the design behave during a regional dependency failure?	Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric.
Which metric reveals the first bottleneck?	Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric.
What consistency does the user actually observe?	Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric.
How would the design change at ten times the traffic?	Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric.

Data questions

+ Partition key
+ Versioning
+ Uniqueness
+ Retention
+ Reconciliation

Operations questions

+ SLO
+ Backlog
+ Capacity
+ Alert
+ Failover test

DESIGN DISCIPLINE

For every box: which requirement justifies it, what cost does it introduce, and what happens when it fails?

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